

Committee: United Nations Security Council

Topic: The Impact of Oil Crises in the Middle East on Global Economic and Political Security

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1. Introduction

Oil sits as one of the world's most strategic resources, influencing factors such as economic development, industrial growth, production of energy, and transportation. The region of the Middle East remains one of the most influential territories on earth for the production, exportation, and reserves of oil. It accounts for around 30% of global oil production and holds nearly 48% of known global oil reserves.¹ Due to the high domestic energy demands from multiple countries across Europe and Asia, the Middle East sustains key significance to global energy security.

Aside from its resources, the Middle East upholds a geographical strategic importance as it contains major shipping routes, including the Strait of Hormuz, one of the world's most important maritime chokepoints, through which one-fifth of global oil consumption is transported each day. Therefore, due to its big and central role in supplying global energy markets, the disruption of Oil production or transportation within the region can have a significant impact on the international community.

It has been seen throughout history that past oil crises in this region have influenced how the market and the world have responded to rising energy prices, economic instability, inflation, and political tensions. A good example of these instances is the 1973 Oil Embargo, which caused economic recessions in multiple countries due to oil prices quadrupling. In the following years, similar events resulted in repeated consequences: The 1990 Gulf Wars caused major supply concerns and a global increase in oil prices, while the 2019 attack on the Saudi Aramco facilities led to oil prices surging up 20% in a single day, along with temporarily knocking out 5.7 million barrels per day (around 5% of the world's oil supply). More recently, the Yemen conflict has been directly linked to attacks on commercial shipping in the Red Sea, which have significantly altered global trade routes, raising concerns over transportation costs and security. An ongoing similar case is the Russia-Ukraine conflict, where ever since the outbreak of the war, oil and gas prices have been well above \$120 per barrel. These instances directly demonstrated how regional instability quickly led to global concern through sanctions on major oil-producing states and strict transportation restrictions on shipping routes.

Oil crisis effects aren't limited solely to the financial markets. Transportation and manufacturing costs are often a result of rising oil prices, which contribute to a series of consequences such as higher fuel and

¹Rasoul Sorkhabi. "How Much Oil in the Middle East?" GeoExpro, 1 Feb. 2014, <https://geoexpro.com/how-much-oil-in-the-middle-easaren't limited solelyrisingcontributemanufacturing/>. Accessed 5 July 2026.

food prices, inflation, and several interruptions to global supply markets. Developing countries are heavily impacted as they greatly rely on imported energy and goods and sustain a limited economic capacity to overcome issues such as sudden price increases.

Therefore, the repercussions stem not only from economic issues but also threaten national security and the stability of peace and international security. Competition for energy resources, as well as defending important energy infrastructure, increases the possibility of tensions among countries, aggravating the probability of military clashes while becoming an impediment to global and regional stability.

2. Definition of Essential Terms

- a) **Oil Crisis:** A situation where the production/supply of oil is severely disrupted or when there is a significant increase in oil prices due to factors such as conflict, natural disasters, sanctions, or political instability. An oil crisis can have substantial effects on the global market, transport, industries, and economic growth, as many countries rely solely on oil as their primary source of energy.
- b) **Energy Security:** The ability of a country to maintain or supply a stable and reliable source of energy. Energy security can be threatened through conflict and regional instability that may cut off the production or transportation of the sole energy supply of a community.
- c) **Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries (OPEC):** An organization composed of different government members composed of oil-influential countries that play a major role in Energy supply and production. They are tasked with maintaining a proper balance between oil and cost, coordinating policies in order to stabilize markets, or to ensure a reliable source of energy supply that is in heavy need of it while protecting their own economic interests.
- d) **Strait of Hormuz:** A waterway between the countries of Iran and Oman (The Persian Gulf and the Gulf of Oman), where a majority of global oil supply passes through each day. An interruption of transportation through this Strait can result in severe consequences such as an increase in global energy prices.
- e) **Critical Energy Infrastructure:** Facilities such as oil fields, pipelines, refineries, storage terminals, ports, and offshore platforms. These systems are essential to the production,

transportation, storage, and processing of energy sources. Any disruption of these facilities can pose threats to energy-reliant countries.

- f) **Oil Embargo:** The intentional disruption and prohibition of oil exportation to specific countries imposed by oil-supplier governments. An oil embargo is a strategy often used in times of conflict as an economics local
- g) **Strategic Petroleum Reserves (SPR):** Reserves of oil strategically stored by governments to utilize in instances where there is a temporary termination of oil supply. Countries implement these to reduce the economic impact that a sudden oil crisis could cause, helping them stabilise before resorting to other measures.
- h) **Energy Diversification:** The act of expanding a government's horizons and open themselves up to find alternative energy sources such as solar, wind, natural gas, or nuclear energy. Diversification helps to reduce vulnerability and reliance on a sole energy source, which can reduce the effects an oil crisis can have on their economy.
- i) **Maritime Chokepoints:** A seaway usually between two or more countries, where major shipping routes and international trade pass through. Both the Strait of Hormuz and Bab el-Mandeb Strait are maritime choke points that carry a great influence in the Middle Eastern region, and any disruption of these can lead to threats to global energy security.

3. General Context

Although both money and energy markets have evolved, the energy space is still characterised by several factors and remains highly dependent on the era of non-renewable energy sources. The Middle East has always been regarded as being in a privileged position in the context of energy markets due to the existence of overwhelmingly significant oil reserves in the region, and therefore may determine the future of the global economy and the future development of energy resources.

Historically, one of the most significant oil crises occurred in 1973, when Arab OPEC members imposed an oil embargo on those who were on the side of Israel during the Yom Kippur War. Oil prices quadrupled at the same time, resulting in inflation, stagnation, and shortages.

There have been recent geopolitical crises that have emphasized the vulnerability of global energy markets. Events like the Iran-Iraq war (1980-1988), the invasion of Kuwait in 1990, the attack on the

Saudi Arabian oil system in 2019, the Russia-Ukraine conflict, and the events in the Red Sea related to the Yemen conflict have shown the impact of regional instability on oil prices and energy security.

The oil crisis brings multiple implications. At the economic level, the crisis raises transportation and production costs in addition to causing inflation, slowing down growth, and leading to potential recessions. Oil-importing countries and developing countries, especially those in Africa, South Asia, and some parts of Latin America, are most hurt by these instances due to dependency on imported energy and an inability to cope with the rising costs involved. At the political level, an oil crisis can lead to the escalation of regional conflicts, foreign interference, increased competition for strategic resources, and put a strain on bilateral relations.

.Recent trends have expanded the notion of energy security, not only to cover threats like cyber attacks directed at energy networks, terrorist activities against oil installations, instability of sea routes, but also the global shift towards clean energies.

Although much is being invested in renewable sources of power, the role of oil remains very important everywhere energy or fuel is consumed, making energy market stability an important issue to the world in renewable sources of power the role of oil remains very important everywhere energy or fuel is consumed, making energy market stability un important issue to the world.

In its capacity as the principal body mandated with maintaining global peace and security, the United Nations Security Council needs to devise both short-term responses to energy-related crises and long-term plans for enhancing energy resilience. With the oil crisis becoming more than just an economic issue, leading to worsening political conflicts and disruption of international trade, multilateral efforts must coordinate to reduce the significance of the crisis on both.

4. Key Parties Involved and their Perspectives

a) International organizations

United Nations Security Council

Aims to ensure peace and security throughout the globe by preventing events that can potentially threaten global energy supplies, alongside the protection of vital energy infrastructure.

United Nations General Assembly and UN agencies

Seek to promote the principles of multilateralism and sustainability in humanitarian assistance and help developing nations tackle the socio-economic consequences of energy crises and disruptions occurring in different parts of the world.

Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries (OPEC)

Advocates to align oil policies of member states, stabilize oil prices, and guarantee effective oil supply in the world market. These goals reflect the organization's adherence to protecting the interests of member states with high reliance on oil revenues.

b) Major States**Saudi Arabia**

Aims to stabilize the situation on the international oil market, to guarantee the security of vital energy pipelines, and to make a strong contribution to the activities of OPEC by being one of the leading oil suppliers.

Iran

Stresses that it is of utmost importance to maintain its national sovereignty and be able to secure the delivery of energy exports, as well as to remove the international restrictions imposed on it, while continuing its efforts to sustain its regional position and economic interests over the long-term.

Iraq

The focus is on the protection of oil facilities and ensuring continuous oil exports, as well as stimulating economic recovery and developing state stability, while the entire economy mainly relies on the revenues gained by means of oil.

United States

Aims to secure international waterways, regulate global energy markets, facilitate international trade, and protect energy interests of its partners. These goals are motivated by the strategic

intention of the United States to prevent regional conflicts from affecting the global economy and trade.

China

Focuses on ensuring security and diversification of energy supply, as well as the functioning of global supply chains and collaboration for ensuring energy security in the long run while abiding by the principle of non-interference in the internal affairs of sovereign states.

Russian Federation

Aims to remain a dominant energy exporter, maintain its influence in international energy markets, and provide stable income flows. These objectives are driven by Russia's substantial economic dependence on hydrocarbon exports and its desire to achieve geopolitical goals.

c) Regional Blocs

European Union (EU)

Prioritizing energy security by means of diversification in the procurement of energy resources is a perfect way of reducing dependency on energy suppliers of energy and poor transportation routes, and establishing favorable cooperation relations with various countries of the world while being aware of the dependency of the European Union on energy imports and processing and the need to strengthen energy market stability.

5. Questions to Consider

1. What are the ways for the international community to reduce its dependency on oil supplies in the Middle East?
2. How can the United Nations Security Council contribute to the protection of critical energy infrastructure and strategic shipping routes?
3. How can a balance be reached between energy security, respect for national sovereignty, and regional stability?
4. Do international strategic petroleum reserves need to be expanded or better coordinated during times of crisis?

What role can energy diversification play in providing long-term economic and political security?

5. What mechanisms can improve international cooperation and information sharing during future oil crises?
6. How can the Security Council deal with emerging threats such as cyberattacks, terrorism, and piracy targeting energy infrastructure?

6. Suggested Resources

a) United Nations Security Council Reports and Resolutions

<https://main.un.org/securitycouncil/en/content/reports>

This source includes official reports and resolutions established and published by the UNSC on matters of international peace and security. Documents are continuously published starting from the year 1946.

b) International Energy Agency (IEA)

<https://www.iea.org/reports/world-energy-outlook-2025>

Published by the IEA in 2025, this resource measures analytical changes and shows forecasts on global energy markets, policies, and trends.

c) Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries (OPEC)

<https://www.opec.org/assets/assetdb/opec-statute.pdf>

This resource illustrates the way the OPEC functions, along with explaining its structure, objectives, and regulations for each member. This statute has been constantly amended since its original creation in 1961.

d) World Bank Energy and Economic Reports

<https://www.opec.org/assets/assetdb/opec-statute.pdf>

In this resource, you can find reports which focus on analysing global energy challenges, economic developments, and sustainable growth, with their latest publication being released in 2025.

e) International Monetary Fund (IMF) Publications

<https://www.opec.org/assets/assetdb/opec-statute.pdf>

This resource focuses on publishing reports examining global economic trends, financial stability, and policy issues. Different editions are published through a set period of time, with multiple current reports available for 2025.

f) United Nations Conference on Trade and Development (UNCTAD)

<https://unctad.org/publications>

The UNCTAD publications focus on sectors such as international trade, investment, and development issues. Final reports are published annually, with updates such as in 2025 where there are multiple publications throughout the year.

g) United Nations Development Programme (UNDP)

<https://www.undp.org/publications>

The UNDP official resource publishes reports which address matters such as human development, sustainability, poverty reductions, and global challenges.

h) BP Statistical Review of World Energy

<https://www.bp.com/en/global/corporate/energy-economics/statistical-review-of-world-energy.html>

This resource provides annual data on the production, consumptions, and reserves of energy. Reports can be found published starting from the year 1952, until the most recent edition in 2024.

7. Conclusion

Oil crises in the Middle East continue to present significant challenges to global economic and political security. Given the region's central role in international energy markets, disruptions can rapidly affect inflation, trade, economic growth, and diplomatic relations across the world.

The Security Council must consider both immediate responses to energy-related disruptions and long-term strategies aimed at strengthening energy resilience, protecting critical infrastructure, promoting peaceful conflict resolution, and enhancing international cooperation. Member states are encouraged to examine the complex relationship between energy security, geopolitical tensions, economic development, and international peace.

Through constructive debate and multilateral cooperation, the committee should seek innovative, realistic, and sustainable solutions capable of addressing both present and future challenges associated with oil crises in the Middle East.

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